

Asterisms

A Sovereign Continuity and Curation Layer for a Life

A life does not occur in a single place.

It is scattered across conversations, photographs, notebooks, medical portals, email threads, browser tabs, code repositories, books, calendars, recordings, laboratory reports, inherited documents, unfinished projects, and moments that were never captured at all. Some of these materials are private. Some are shared. Some are consequential. Some are beautiful but difficult to explain. Many become inaccessible, decontextualized, or effectively lost—not because they ceased to matter, but because the systems that held them were never designed to help a life remain intelligible to itself.

Asterisms begins from a simple premise:

A person should be able to remain in meaningful relation to the materials, histories, questions, and possibilities of their own life.

This is not merely a problem of storage.

Cloud drives, note applications, archives, search engines, patient portals, messaging platforms, social networks, and AI chat histories all preserve fragments. Yet they typically preserve them as isolated possessions of separate systems. They are optimized for transactions, documents, feeds, workflows, or retrieval of already-known facts. They are rarely designed to help a person notice that a question from ten years ago has returned in a new form; that a medical result belongs beside a change in sleep, food, work, relationship, or place; that a diagram from one field offers language for a problem in another; or that an unfinished reflection has quietly become central.

Asterisms is an attempt to build a different kind of infrastructure.

It is a sovereign continuity and curation layer for a life: a locally governed field in which records, materials, reflections, questions, relationships, and emerging formations can remain available across time, retain their lineage, and become newly meaningful in changing contexts.

It is not a single app, a master database, a personal knowledge graph, or an AI memory feature.

It is a living field.

The problem is fragmentation, not merely forgetting

Contemporary life is increasingly mediated by systems that remember selectively and separately.

A hospital may retain a laboratory result but not connect it to the conditions under which it was taken, the medications that preceded it, the other institutions that measured related things, or the person's own

account of what was happening. A chat platform may preserve an extraordinary exchange until an export format changes, an account is lost, a thread becomes difficult to retrieve, or the useful insight remains buried in thousands of turns. A code repository may preserve exact revisions while shedding the conversations, doubts, images, sketches, and reasons that gave the work its direction.

The result is not simply missing information. It is loss of continuity.

A person may still possess records while losing the ability to recognize what those records mean together. They may still have memories while lacking the context, companionship, or tools required to revisit them safely. They may still have choices while losing the material, relational, temporal, and embodied conditions that make those choices meaningful.

Asterisms is concerned with this loss of continuity.

It asks:

- What must remain available for a life to remain intelligible to itself?
- How can materials retain their original integrity while still entering into new relationships?
- How can a person preserve uncertainty, unfinishedness, contradiction, beauty, and fascination without forcing everything into a premature conclusion?
- How can systems help people notice possibilities, patterns, tensions, and openings without claiming to own or define their lives?
- How might a person become more able to carry forward their own history, purposes, and agency across changing technologies, institutions, and circumstances?

A living field, not a filing system

Asterisms does not assume that every material has one correct location, one dominant meaning, or one project to which it belongs.

A paper may matter for ecology, governance, disability, personal memory, software design, and a future question not yet named. A medical record may also be part of a story about work, nutrition, grief, sleep, movement, access, or possibility. A fragment from a conversation may become a concept, a design principle, a chapter, a friendship marker, or nothing at all for many years.

The point is not to impose a perfect taxonomy.

The point is to preserve the field in which relationships can continue to emerge.

An asterism, in astronomy, is a recognizable pattern among stars. It is not necessarily an official constellation, and its stars may also participate in other patterns. The pattern is real as a way of seeing, but it does not claim exclusive ownership of the stars.

Asterisms takes that image seriously.

Asterisms may exist within Asterisms. A person's larger field may contain overlapping asterisms around Better Angels, family, health, a home, a research question, a creative project, a friendship, an institution, a period of life, or an unnamed emerging concern. These are not rigid folders, sealed domains, or final ontological categories. They are revisable fields of attention.

A material may participate in many of them at once.

Materials, formations, and the right to remain unfinished

Asterisms begins with materials.

A material may be a paper, book, recording, image, diagram, code repository, conversation, lab report, audio fragment, dataset, notebook, web capture, letter, sketch, object record, or unfinished thought. Materials are preserved in their original forms wherever possible. Their source, history, transformations, and uncertainties remain visible.

But a life of thought cannot be reduced to what arrives from elsewhere.

Attention itself produces new material.

A phrase that keeps returning. A question. A distinction. A visual arrangement. A synthesis of several sources. A design principle. A map. An essay fragment. A new project. A recognition that two things belong near one another even when their relationship is not yet understood.

Asterisms calls these **formations**.

Formations are not merely notes about "real" materials. They are new materials in their own right. They arise through encounter, reflection, conversation, experiment, memory, and association. They may remain tentative, private, contradictory, or unfinished. They may later become central. They may dissolve. They may fork into several different futures.

The system should not force them to become polished documents before they are allowed to exist.

It should be able to preserve statements such as:

- This seems important, but I do not know why yet.
- Keep these near one another.
- There may be a bridge here.
- This is beautiful and troubling.
- This keeps returning.
- This may be central.
- This needs another reading.
- This is in productive tension with something else.
- I do not want to lose this before I understand it.

These are not failures of organization. They are forms of intellectual and human attention.

Provenance, uncertainty, and trust

Asterisms is not an argument for indiscriminate accumulation or machine-made certainty.

The more consequential a system becomes, the more important it is to preserve distinctions among:

- what was directly recorded;
- what was extracted;
- what was inferred;
- what was proposed by an AI;
- what was observed by a person;
- what was jointly formed through conversation;
- what remains uncertain;
- what may be acted upon, and under what authority.

Every material, relation, annotation, and formation should be able to carry a context of provenance, sensitivity, uncertainty, permission, and actionability.

This is not a special rule for medical records, financial records, or other officially sensitive categories. Life does not divide itself neatly that way. A supplement routine, a sleeping pattern, a house plan, a private conversation, a legal document, a photograph, a piece of code, and a note about fear or hope may all be consequential in different ways.

Asterisms therefore seeks a common language for care across the entire field.

The question is not simply, “Is this private?”

It is also:

- Who may encounter this, and under what conditions?
- Who may annotate, transform, connect, disclose, or act upon it?
- What is the basis of consent or delegation?
- What confidence should anyone place in this interpretation?
- What would be lost if this were simplified, detached from context, or made permanent too soon?
- What must remain visible to the future person whose life this is?

Beyond retrieval: semantic companionship

Much of current information technology assumes that the central task is retrieval: find the document, answer the question, summarize the history, recommend the next action.

Those capabilities matter. But they are not enough.

Asterisms is interested in a deeper form of support: semantic companionship.

Semantic companionship does not mean that a machine becomes a substitute for human relationship or human judgment. It means that a person can be accompanied by systems capable of helping hold context, notice recurrence, preserve unresolved questions, surface forgotten material, distinguish evidence from interpretation, and support return without taking over the work of meaning.

A useful system might help ask:

- You have returned to this concern several times over six years. What changed each time?
- These three sources use different language but appear to be circling the same problem.
- This medical shift coincides with several changes in your life. Which are comparable, and which are not?
- This concept has become a bridge between Better Angels, Vital Continuity, and Understory.
- You once marked this as beautiful and unexplained. Would you like to revisit it now?
- These materials are beginning to form something new.

The system should not decide the answer for the person.

It should help make the field more available for thought, action, relationship, and self-recognition.

Relation to Better Angels

Asterisms belongs naturally beside Building Our Better Angels.

Better Angels is concerned with resourcing humans toward lives of their own choosing in a sustainable future. It asks what kinds of infrastructure, intelligence, governance, and companionship might help people live with greater agency, continuity, mutual regard, and capacity for moral and practical action.

Asterisms is one possible substrate for that work.

A person's agency does not reside only in declared preferences or momentary choices. It depends upon an embodied, relational, material, and temporal field that can either support or erode the ability to live by those preferences.

Asterisms helps preserve and make available that field.

It does so not by reducing a life to a profile, a behavioral model, or an optimized recommendation stream, but by holding the materials through which a person's own history, questions, relationships, commitments, and possibilities can remain present.

In this sense, Asterisms is related to vital continuity.

Chat systems often maintain a thin form of continuity through remembered preferences, conversation summaries, tone instructions, and recent context. Asterisms imagines a deeper continuity layer: one that can hold enough of the material, relational, embodied, and temporal context of a life for that life to remain navigable to itself.

This continuity is not only retrospective.

It is also prospective. It concerns the preservation and enlargement of viable possibility.

A local-first and federated future

Asterisms should begin locally.

The original materials of a life should not depend entirely on a company's cloud, a changing subscription, a proprietary export format, or a single institution's willingness to retain access. A person should be able to keep their own corpus, inspect it, back it up, move it, and choose how it participates in wider systems.

Local-first does not mean isolated.

Asterisms may eventually support shared asterisms, collaborative fields, family archives, research commons, care networks, project spaces, and federated public work. But sharing should be intentional, legible, and revisable. A shared formation should not require the surrender of all surrounding context. A person should be able to participate in common meaning-making without losing sovereignty over their own materials.

The long-term aspiration is not one global repository of everyone's life.

It is an ecology of interoperable, consentful, overlapping fields.

What Asterisms is not

Asterisms is not:

- a surveillance archive;
- a quantified-self dashboard;
- a conventional personal knowledge-management system;
- a universal ontology;
- a single master graph;
- a replacement for clinicians, friends, institutions, or communities;
- a machine that gets to decide what matters;
- a promise that every ambiguity can be resolved;
- an excuse to accumulate everything without care;
- a substitute for consent, trust, judgment, or companionship.

It is an effort to build better conditions for those things.

The first task

The first phase of Asterisms is called **The Gathering**.

The Gathering is not yet about building a final interface, graph, or intelligence layer. It is about creating a durable field into which scattered materials can enter once, retain their original forms and lineage, become addressable, and return in meaningful ways.

The initial work is modest but foundational:

- preserve original materials;
- record where they came from;
- create stable anchors into them;
- make them searchable and revisitable;
- distinguish source, derivative, inference, reflection, and formation;
- allow relationships to remain tentative;
- create review surfaces that return meaning rather than clerical burden;
- build the operational systems that let agents do routine work without being granted uncontrolled authority.

The test is simple:

Can a person place a paper, conversation, image, record, fragment, or question into the field once—and later encounter it with enough context, lineage, and relational possibility for something new to emerge?

If the answer becomes yes, then Asterisms has begun to do its work.

An invitation

Asterisms is still a formation.

Its language, architecture, boundaries, and practices remain open to revision. It will need technical rigor, ethical care, aesthetic imagination, and repeated confrontation with real lives and real materials. It will need to earn trust through its behavior, not its aspirations.

But the need is already visible.

Lives are being fragmented by systems that remember in pieces. The materials of meaning are accumulating faster than people can integrate them. Institutions retain records without continuity. AI systems are becoming increasingly capable of conversation while remaining thinly connected to the histories and conditions that make a life intelligible.

Asterisms asks whether we can build something more faithful.

Not an all-knowing system.

Not a final map.

A field in which what matters can remain available long enough to be noticed, held, questioned, woven, and carried forward.